ERA 4

A New Government

1776 – 1791

Articles of Confederation · Constitution · Bill of Rights

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

How did the failures of the Articles of Confederation shape the compromises of the Constitution?

KEY TERMS

Articles of Confederation · Shays' Rebellion · Great Compromise · Three-Fifths Compromise · Federalists vs. Anti-Federalists · Bill of Rights

ALIGNED TO

CED Topics 3.7–3.9 · AMSCO Ch. 3.7–3.9

AMERICA'S FIRST GOVERNMENT

The Articles of Confederation

A Deliberately Weak Government

Fearful of tyranny, Americans made the central government too weak

I

No Executive

No president to enforce national law.

II

No Power to Tax

Congress could only request money from the states.

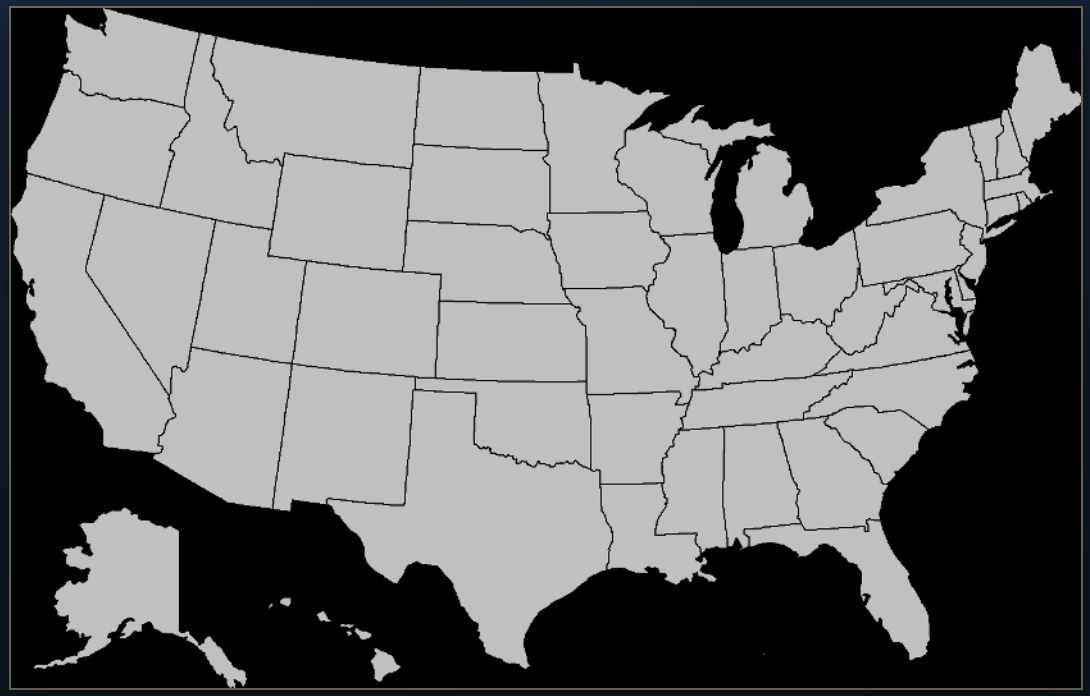
III

No National Court

No federal judiciary to settle disputes.

One Great Success: The Northwest Ordinance

- The **Northwest Ordinance** (1787) organized western lands for settlement.
- It created an orderly path for new states to enter as equals.
- It also banned slavery in the Northwest Territory.



Shays' Rebellion, 1786



- Debt-ridden Massachusetts farmers led by **Daniel Shays** shut down courts.
- The weak government struggled to put down the revolt.
- It shocked elites into demanding a stronger national government.

PHILADELPHIA, 1787

The Constitutional Convention

A Convention Behind Closed Doors

- Delegates met in Philadelphia—officially just to 'amend' the Articles.
- **George Washington** presided; debates were kept secret.
- They chose instead to build an entirely new government.



Large States vs. Small States

The Virginia Plan

Favored large states

- Representation based on **population**.
- A strong national government.
- Big states would dominate Congress.

The New Jersey Plan

Favored small states

- **Equal** representation for every state.
- A weaker, confederation-style government.
- Protected small states from being outvoted.

A Bundle of Compromises

The Constitution was born of hard bargains

COMPROMISE	THE CONFLICT	THE RESOLUTION
Great Compromise	Representation: population vs. equality	Bicameral Congress—House by population, Senate equal
Three-Fifths	Do enslaved people count for representation?	Count 3/5 of the enslaved population
Commerce	North wanted trade power; South feared it	Congress regulates trade; no slave-import ban until 1808

SECTION

The Ratification Debate

A Nation Argues



- Ratification split Americans into two camps.
- The **Federalist Papers** made the case for the Constitution.
- The promise of a **Bill of Rights** won over the doubters.

Federalists vs. Anti-Federalists

Federalists

For ratification

- Wanted a strong central government.
- Led by **Hamilton, Madison,** and Jay.
- Argued the Constitution's checks prevented tyranny.

Anti-Federalists

Against ratification

- Feared a distant, too-powerful government.
- Wanted power kept with the states.
- Demanded a **Bill of Rights** to protect liberty.

SECTION

The Constitution & Bill of Rights

How the Constitution Limits Power

I

Federalism

Power is divided between national and state governments.

II

Separation of Powers

Three branches—legislative, executive, judicial.

III

Checks & Balances

Each branch can limit the others.

The Bill of Rights, 1791

The Anti-Federalists' price for ratification

AMENDMENT	WHAT IT PROTECTS
1st	Speech, religion, press, assembly, and petition
2nd	The right to bear arms
3rd–4th	No forced quartering; no unreasonable searches
5th–8th	Rights of the accused and fair trials
9th–10th	Rights reserved to the people and the states

KEY TAKEAWAYS

A New Government

1. The **Articles of Confederation** made the government too weak; its one triumph was the **Northwest Ordinance**, but **Shays' Rebellion** exposed its failures.

2. The Convention resolved deep divisions through compromise—the **Great Compromise**, the **Three-Fifths Compromise**, and the **Commerce Compromise**.

3. **Federalists** and **Anti-Federalists** clashed over ratification; the **Bill of Rights** secured a government of **federalism**, **separation of powers**, and **checks and balances**.

DISCUSS & APPLY

A New Government

AP HISTORICAL REASONING PRACTICE

CAUSATION

Explain how **Shays' Rebellion** changed elite opinion and made a stronger central government possible.

COMPARISON

Compare the **Federalist** and **Anti-Federalist** visions of the proper role of government.

CONTINUITY & CHANGE

How did the **Constitution** both continue and break from the Articles of Confederation?

Up next — **Lesson 9: Shaping a New Republic** (Washington's presidency & Hamilton's financial plan)